Ascents

Poems

OpenMiracles

I grew up
Listening
Of coming
Miracles.

And now
They rise
And fall
From the sky.

At an age
When looking
Up is difficult,
Just thinking of

HAL and why.

Ascending

Beyond
A lone
Human
Being

I voice
Millions
Of shared

Feelings

And sing
Among
The dead
And living

New songs
Created
In the
Beginning.

Procurando Meu Canto

Achei minha voz
Conheci os amigos
Relembrei meus avós.

Procurando meu canto
Senti minha dor
Lavei minha alma
Expirei meu calor.

Procurando meu canto
Construi minhas casas
Reatei as raizes
Soltei minhas asas.

Procurando meu canto
Cantei pra Você
Encontrei, finalmente,
Minha razão de viver.

Bedtime Shemah

I have died
So many times
That when I go
It won't be new

My eyes will
close
My mouth ajar
I'll say the words
I know are true:

There is
no doubt
There is no I
There's only Truth
There's only You

Then,
wrapped in white
I'll wait and see
The Heavens' first
Light shades of blue

I'll give
my thanks
And wash my hands
Shake off the dust
And start anew.

I am the Place

In memory of Neely Snyder and in honor of her heroic husband, Joshua.

I am the Place

In which you sit
Life, vest,
Oxygen, mask.

I am the belt
Holding you tight
Buckling and
Unbuckling.

I am the seat
That makes you float
If you hug me
Against your chest.

I am the One
Who comforts you,
Pilot signaling
It's safe to stand.

Note: "The Place" (HaMakom) is one of G-d's names, used primarily in the words of consolation used in addressing those in mourning, "sitting Shivah": May the Omnipresent (lit. "the Place") comfort you among the mourners of Zion and Jerusalem."

Jacob, Israel

I try so hard
In every way
To get Your smile
And get Your say

Perhaps one day
After all that trying
After all that living
After all that dying

My seeds will grow
To become trees
And testify
About that child

And then that man
Who tried so hard
And finally got
What he couldn't see.

Yom Yerushalayim

Chega o dia que cansa
Ser manso, pacato
Sensato, puxa saco
Chega a hora que explode
A força enforcada
Feroz e selvagem
Com garras, coragem
Jumento tornado
Tigre de fogo e carvão
Reconquista por fim
O próprio coração
Cidade da paz
E temor.

Nepal

Completely nothing
He couldn't move
His mind a daze
His world confused

Not knowing
If he was coming

Or he was going.

Out of fuel
For quite some time
His body failing
As were his rhymes

He'd sing
His final song
And then he'd go.

Then he remembered
An ancient shepherd
Who worked for love
For seven years, then seven more

They went by slow
But even so
They were like days.

He too felt dead
For quite some time
And yet he knew, he surely knew
That like the dew

He'd be revived.

PS: : "Love is as strong as death" (Song of Songs 8:16)

It Comes as No Surprise

That outside the
Land of giants
Everything again
Feels so small.

If after 9 months
It took me
Almost a decade
To settle,

Is it really a shock
That I'd return
With my head again
In those clouds?

No longer breathing
Its air, bathing
In Its water,

No longer standing
On Its earth, warm
From Its fire.

It's all
To be expected,
Yet painful
All the same.

PS: Israel has four main holy cities:Jerusalem (fire), Hebron (earth), Tiberias (water) and Tsfat (air)

In the Holy Land

The angels I've seen
Have no chubby cheeks,
Fluffy feathers or wings.

They have just direction
To give and care deeply,
Few words, hardly any expression.

Alive at Week's End

Not because
I earn or
Spend

But because
I yearn,
Expand.

Weak finished,
I learn to
Stand

Witness,
Return, and
Mend.

I Don't Have All the Answers

I don't have all the answers,
Not even the questions.

All I have is the will
To learn and to change.

And that's all I need.

Allah huAkhbar

G-d is Great
He is All and
More

People peep
Like mice at bar

Holes

And make Him

small.

The Left Leg

Was never meant
To be the head.

I hold my own
But seek balance
In my right twin.

I flex and bend
So not to brake.

Protect my toes,
My heal and soul
With my thick skin.

Come and see

Come and hear,
Smell and touch,
Taste and fear,
Love so much.

Come and sing.

Come and heal,
Smile and try,
Dance and feel,
Laugh and cry.

Whatever you do,
Make sure to come.
Uman Uman Rosh Hashana...

In the Morning

I wrap myself
With explosives
Close to my heart,
Arms, and head.

I search for
The biggest crowd
Of Jewish men,
Covering my face
With a cloak.

I anxiously wait
To sacrifice
Body and Soul,
Lighting a Fire
For Life, and not death.

Surrounded by Distant Family

Sitting in a gymnasium,
Praying for their release
I could not help but think that
We are all kidnapped children.
(Literally, Tinokot sheNishbe'u)

Yet, we too are not alone.
We are One, and we have each other.
We've been united and must remain so,
For that is the ultimate goal, the only way out,

The source of our redemption.

Return us to You,
And we will return, together.
Bring back your boys.

After a Long Day

I opened up my computer and
A pop-up window appeared.
It had a heart and read in pink:
“Does Skype power your passion?”

They do not know that Mine is
Vast and total.

If only there was a Skype for it,
Something to keep me connected.
If only I could see and still
Listen, talk, and live...

Then perhaps I would not feel
The emptiness.

The crater that remains from the blast
That formed me into a vessel,
Rendering other food tasteless and
The air outside of it impure.

Here, there is no way to fill
The void, I know.

There are but moments of brightness,
The promise of reward, and
The gratification in knowing that

I do not want or need it.

The only true reward is to serve
The One I love.

Everything else is just a
Flashing light on a screen
On which I must click,
and hit “OK.”

The Heart of the Matter

When the soul first enters the body,
It asks: “Why do I need all this opposition?
I already had a place to live,
So why do I have to conquer this one?”

With time, it realizes that to be truly whole
And holy requires both body and soul,
East and West, the Jerusalem above
And the Jerusalem below.

Some points

At some points,
I worried about
Sounding smart.
At some others,
Sounding funny.
Buy these days,
All I care about
Is sounding true,
Like my Self.

From my posts

Some people
May think
I'm crazy.

Of course,
I am.
Isn't everyone
Who is in love?

180

There's a lady
Who for years
I would see

On the street
Taking walks
Dragging half
Of her body.

She's here now
And I cannot
Believe my eyes.

Her back straight,
No longer angled
Forty-five degrees,
She is running.

Tag Me In Your Prayers

Tag me
In your
Prayers

Like what's
Behind
Purim
Masks

Beyond
Yellow
Electronic
Smiles

React
To More
Than just
Posts

And you
Will come
Face to
Face

With the
Fact that
I am
You

And our
Life is
In a
Book

Of the
Kind One
Has to
Open.

Some Times

No matter how right
And successful
The operation,

How strong the bond
And bright the light
After the darkness,

The wound remains
And the heart still
Beats a bit broken.

Just Paths

(In Honor of Aventura Chabad's Building Plan Approval)

Just Paths

The truth is that
There's no quick fix
Just simply paths
Of the Tzadik.

No lasting signs,
Bright finish lines,
Cures from coffee,
Much less from wine.

There's no plateau,
Or staying still,
You either grow
Or you will wilt.

Just step by step,
That's all there is.
A few more up
Until you slip.

Then comes the trick,
To just restart,
Get up and go
Until you find

That brick by brick,
Through sweat and tears
A few mistakes
And many fears

You've built a home.

Through the Cracks

In sealed windows
The students peaked
At passing cars.

Modern flashy
Models, foreign
Convertibles.

Fast exposing
All that South Beach
Had to offer.

Class was dismissed,
Car pollution
Now filled the air.

The kids had failed
To focus on
The interior,

The future proud
Lessors bound to
Repeat afresh
Rookie mistakes.

The new teacher
Still deciding
If to stand for
His principals.

It was too late
The cracks had long
Been open to
The heat and dirt.

The solution
Was to shed more
Light and reach for
The Menorah

For the dealer
Across the street
Had captured the
Imagination.

Tu B'Shvat

The best is when
You start from scratch
All that could fail
Indeed fell flat.

And now, the Skies
Open to your plea
Give you a chance
To breathe and see.

To create anew
Just like He did
Something from none
Humility.

And that small seed
Blown in the wind
Will find new lands
New shades, new kin.

And water, too.
And yes, some sun,
Who would have thought
It'd be so fun.

Life is so good
When you are there
Not to decide
All that is fair.

Judge Not

If I pass
On this
Great
Opportunity

If I choose
Just to
Stay in
My place

If I sing
To the
Few and
The tender

Believe me,
It won't
All go
To waste.

And if you
Don't, it's
O.K.
With me.

Schwalbe (Andorinha)

Schwalbe

Tiro o
Peso
Que sou
Algo,
Não sou

Deixo o
Vento
Que me
Leve,
E voo

Felsen (Rocha)

Felsen

Desço
Desconheço
O caminho
Mas começo

Você
Espera só
De mim
Um sorriso

Que dou
Mesmo sem
Me sentir
Obrigado

Felzenszwalbe (Andorinha da Rocha)

Como faço
Como traço
Tantos passos
Até Você?
Tantos caminhos
Sábios livros
Pergaminhos
E eu? Tão limitado.

Como faço?
Agradeço
Esse contato
É isso.
Porque o momento
Mesmo modesto
É por Você̂
Multiplicado
Criando
Mundos de
Alegria
Infinita e ilimitada.

Life of Pi

I live along

A narrow bridge
A tightrope of sorts
In which I try to balance

Twenty-two letters
Constantly on my mind
And seven lights
Burning from my heart

Cycles of weeks
Three followed by sevens
Followed by three
From mourning to morning

It's an uphill battle
A long but short way
With area and circumference
Both great and small

That curves around
A radius defined
By how much I am
Willing to give

And yet the entire circle
Is still not more than zero
But if it touches yours
It's Infinite. ∞

OBS: The period from 17th of Tammuz to the 9th of Av is known as the 3 Weeks (although it has 22 days). It is a period of mourning followed by seven weeks of consolation. The seven weeks of the Omer is also a period mourning, and both the three weeks and the seven weeks will be times of joy in the future. The seven weeks is connected to the seven emotional sefirot, and the three weeks appear to be connected to the twenty-two Hebrew letters. The reading for the 9th of Av, Lamentations, is in acrostic form, with each chapter having a verse for each letter (chapter 3 has three for each),

The number Pi is almost exactly the ratio of twenty-two divided by seven. Area is defined as Pi (22/7) x the Square of the Radius, and the Circumference is 2 x Pi (22/7) x Radius.

In Order to Teach

And here
I thought
That I
Had found it.

And that
My balance
Had been
Reached.

The offer
Came and
I sure
Took it.

To pray
And study,
Work and …
Teach.

And now
I see
How much
I've grinded

And how
My energy
Has
Peaked.

I long
To fit
In every
Part of me.

In every
Day and
Every
Week.

I must
Admit
I've thought
Of quitting
But then
A voice

Keeps me
Upbeat.
Keeping
It up
Will not
Be easy

Yet the
Reward
Is worth
The risk.

Nachshon (Sétimo dia de Pessach)

As vezes me sinto só
E não vejo solução

São nesses momentos então
Que sei que são passageiros

Que abraço o mundo inteiro
E nos lanço com as mãos

a D'us.

Sei Lá, No Celular

Totalmente divididos
Pela raiva de todos
Pelo medo de tudo
Todo mundo meio
Que nos fez ficar
Loucos e mudos
Cegos e surdos
Sem saber em
Quem crer e
Sem poder
O mundo
Mudar.

Água Viva

Cheguei nesse mundo
Há séculos e há segundos,
Meses, milênios, minutos,
Dias e decadas,
Todo possível
Espaço de tempo.

Mas estou só
De passagem e
Mais cada passo que
Dou na viagem
Me dá mais razão
De ficar e de ir.

Me dói. Só me mexo
Porque me puxo
Pra água viva
Por onde caio com

Todo meu pranto.
E aí me levanto.

Quando levanto, canto
Com tudo e com todos
Lutando e de luto
Por mim e por outros
Me esgoelo calado
Em pé e sentado, esgotado

Me abro pra Ele e
Confesso, agradeço
Por tudo e por todos
Por cada segundo
Mês, milênio, minuto
De cada caída.

Food Sensitivity

Unabated by
Misplaced shame
Or other such
Idolatry,

I found the cure
To times of weary
Inactivity.

It was not to cut
The red or blue
Pills Morpheus
Had given me,

But instead increase
Their colors and

Variety.

While I may pass on
Caetano's rain
Sweat, and beer due to
Immodesty,

I'll claim my roots
At least, in coffee,
Wine and açaí.

Flattening the Curve (Erev Rosh Chodesh Nissan 5780)

Flattening the Curve

I ordered
Flat bread
For a week.

I ate it
In my flat
By myself.

For one moment,
I was healed,
I was free.

Not enough.
I ran out,
And remain

Flattered
By the likes
Of many

I'll need
Another
Month's supply

To flatten
Myself
All over

Again.

Forgetting Thee

It's clear to me
I must return
And make a "kli"
And if I don't
Remind us now
Shabbat will come
To then refresh
Whatever's left
In memory.

"If I forget thee, O Jerusalem, let my right hand forget her cunning. Let my tongue cleave to the roof of my mouth, if I remember thee not; if I set not Jerusalem above my chiefest joy. Remember, O Lord, against the children of Edom the day of Jerusalem." (Psalm 137. Yom Yerushalayim, Jerusalem Day, is the 28th of Iyar).

Pesach Sheini (The Second Passover)

I'm constantly haunted
By the overwhelming
Feeling that whatever

I'm doing is not enough,
That I'm not meeting
My most basic obligations

And that the day of reckoning
Will come and I will be
Forced to admit it.

So I admit it now.

What I give certainly
Does not compare with
What I take.

I do not deserve what I have,
And am still very far, relying
Completely on His mercy.

So now that I've gotten
All that off my chest
And set all pretensions aside

I can go back to work
Because it's never too late
To burn off the yeast and bring

The proper sacrifice
With humble bread and bitter herbs
In order, to be free.

Reflexao

Depois de meses, fiquei olhando pro céu. Naquela vastidão, foi tão fácil ver o nada que sou, que me deu vontade de cantar.

No dia seguinte, fiquei olhando meus filhos brincando. Pensei que deve ser assim mesmo que Ele fica nos olhando, e me veio uma certa paz.

Talvez seja preciso só isso. Saber quando ser nada, quando ser tudo, e lembrar de se deixar ficar olhando...

K.I.S.S.

K.I.S.S.*

And yet there is
A simple all
Encompassing
Remedy

To remember
And not forget
The way that all
Is meant to be

To look beyond
And raise the mind
To a higher plain
Reality

Back to the Source
Where all is joy
And all is One
Simplicity.

* “Keep It Simple Stupid”

Open

My lips
Because
I can't
Seem to
See past
What is
In it
For me
So to
Unfool
Myself
Then my
Mouth shall
Declare
Your praise.

Rio, Rosh Chodesh Tammuz

When
You're left
To enjoy
The cream
Of the land
What's there
Not to like
Between
The sea and
The sand
I came
Not to spy
On all the
Naked lies
Or uncover
The shame
So close
To the game
That manages
Still to
Be the talk
Of the
Town.

Facing Facebook

When the screen grows dim

And you lose focus, hooked, faced
With the dizzying news and noise,

General, impersonal, fake,
Vague, unlikely, faceless

Complex, incomplete, remember

That after all is said and done
All you have is a mountain,
A field, and a home.

The ladder you dream of climbing,
The plot in which you chose to plant,
And the one to whom you will return.

You know it's all just One, yet
All you'll truly have is home,
Along with those let in,

And those that out will come.

Miami

Eu que fui
Meio louco
Vivi de tudo
Um pouco

Mas até que
Chegue o moço
Não troco por nada
Isso aqui.

Minha capital,
Grandeza sem igual (em potencial)
Ou alguém normal,
Mistura tropical

De Nova Iorque, Rio,
Nice, Odessa,

Havana, Disney,
Buenos Aires, Haiti.

Translation

Me, who's been
Kind of crazy
Lived it all
a bit

But until
The man arrives
I switch for nothing
This here.

My capital
Greatness without equal (in potential)
Or anyone normal
Tropical mix

Of New York, Rio,
NIce, Odessa,
Havana, Disney,
Buenos Aires, Haiti.

Rachel

Many think that for
The Messiah to come
There must be war.
In truth, there must be peace.

The only weapon
Needed to conquer
The entire world

Will be a mother's prayer.

Landing Again

I am
Here now,
And have
A G-d.

For Him,
I still
Never
Had left.

I hope
One day
To feel
That, too.

Tenth Sense

The Song
Of Mashiach
Is simple,

Its sound
Is the beat
Of the heart.

Its smell
Is pure
Inspiration,

Its sight
Is the light

Of the sun.

Its taste
Is new and
familiar,

Its touch
Is a hug
Nicely done.

Give and Take

There was a time
When all I sought
Was simple pleasure

Which then evolved
To seeking more the
Spiritual kind

Now even that
Cannot compare
To one small measure

Of knowing that
I took Your Name
And made it mine.

Selichót

No meio
Da madrugada
Saio
Do quarto
Pra pedir
Perdão

Do oitavo
Ao térreo
Volto
Inteiro
Refletindo
Sua perfeição.

L'Chaim

It's enough
Said Moses
To Korach

When his wife
Made him not
Know his place.

Enough, said
Samuel
To Saul

After he
Failed to see
His mistake.

So enough
Of you, too

My dear friend.

I'm happy
To have had
What we had

For as short
And as long
As it was.

It's been fun
It seemed grand
But that's life.

Down in Downtown Miami... Looking Up

For the past few days, I've seen a lot of new faces among the homeless in downtown Miami, close to my job. Two caught my attention. They chose to lie down, shirtless, on what has always been for me the most disgusting piece of concrete in all of downtown, by a sewage disposal, under the metro-mover, at the back entrance to Macy's. The stench of urine, feces, and all sorts of green chemicals (incongruously just meters and a double-door away from air-conditioned opulent fashion displays) is abhorrent, but these half-crazy men, laying there, asking indefinitely for spare change, consigned to their misery, is infinitely more shocking. Do they not realize anymore how low they've fallen? Not being homeless, bedless, shirtless, but specifically choosing to wallow in the filthiest block of perhaps all of Miami? "How can the image of G-d live in such a dumpster?," I pondered. Then I immediately thought, "Am I really any better?" I know that I could easily fall into something just like that, were it not for His constant mercy. And, even where I am right now, so fragile and vulnerable, compared to His Place is it not much worse than that filthy corner? Am I not homeless and shirtless when it comes to Torah and Mitzvot? And yet during this entire month, the month of the 13 Attributes of His mercy, the King leaves His Palace and comes into this lowly field, this empty lot, greets this half-crazy, nauseatingly dirty and pungent wanderer, smiles and asks, "What can I do for you My son?" "Take me home, Father. Take me home. Lift me up, help me walk, perhaps on the way I'll realize where I was and where it is that I truly belong..."

Selichot

I have died
So many times
That when I go
It won't be new

My eyes will close
My mouth ajar
I'll say the words
I know as true:

There is no doubt
There is no I
There's only Truth
There's only You

Then, wrapped in white
I'll wait and see
The Heavens' first
Light shades of blue

I'll give my thanks
And wash my hands
Shake off the dust
And start anew.

The Market of Shabbos

I want to get to a place
Where I don't have the time
To think about images

Too busy in cycles of
Informing and exchanging
Taking flight and upgrading
Deciphering and deplaning

Keeping up with the beat
Of the conductor,
The master of
Prayer.

Yom Kippur

My love, in My eyes,
Is the apex of beauty.

My people are perfect
Like the cries of a child

Never a fall
From which it doesn't recover.

Not a single blemish
That I can't brush aside.

It always looks tall
From the top of My shoulders.

Calm and collected
As it's held in My arms.

I Am Not

Interested
In idols
Of humans.
I'm Jewish
After all.

I wish I
Didn't need
Labels: white
Versus black
Man, woman
Short and tall.

I hope one
Day to care
Just for You
Who is Big
And not me
Who am small.

To break through
And connect
And just do
My best not
To need so
Many walls.

Yonah (Dove)

It's time
To fly,
Ben Amitai

The trial is over,
Victory sealed
Our pact renewed
My truth revealed.

Now, shine your light
From miles away
Like those before
For those today.

It's not too early,
It's not too late.
Pour out your joy
My pure young mate.

Please be at peace
And sing My song
Let out your smile
Don't wait too long.

This Yom Kippur

I forgive

Those that showed me the ugly side of
Religion.

That took what was most dear to me and
Flushed it down the toilet.

Who stole, injured, raped, murdered
With actions but also with words.

That constantly asked, demanded, asked, demanded, and asked again without shame.

And when you didn't give were made to feel
Irrelevant.

Who engaged in false flattery, while
Thinking first and foremost of themselves,
I forgive.

And I start anew.

Hoping somehow that this year will be Different.

That I will not be asked for anything that
I cannot afford.

That I will be only with those who love me
For who I am.

With people that are real, like children.
I forgive and I pray

To be forgiven.

Directions

If it were
Up to me
I'd take on
Every stringency

I'd spend my days
In thought and prayer
From text to text
And lose myself in mystery

Then realize it never was
Or ever will be up to me.
It's always been about some
One else who begs us all

To go down to Him.

Neo Batman Superman, Dad

I found the red
And Robin, too.
I'll take the red
And take the blue.

I also found
My kryptonite
Rose from the ground
With my sun's light.

I'll have my cake
And eat it, three
Just have to make
It gluten free.

Neo Batman Potter Morning

I wake up reciting
Ancient writing
And washing
The scar in
My forehead.

I then take a blue pill,

Levothyroxine
Cape and belt
Are strapped in
Arm and head
Gear, Tefillin
For Robin
And for red

I'm still waiting.

Hypertension

My Heart is attacked
My Joseph in flames
Inpatient admission
Strong pulse still remains.

David's divided
Arteries and veins
His doctors are reckless
His arms are enchained.

Truth will not sprout
Without fertile ground
In a Mount full of foxes
No search for a hound.

Now and Here

I yearn for
A language
That all
Can hear.

A message
For once
Not based
On fear.

A prayer
For peace
To bless,
Endear.

For light that
Is sweet,
Human,
Sincere.

For breath that
Is felt
From afar
And from near.

A vessel
That's true,
Present
And clear.

The Older You Get

Time really does start to fly,
And not only when you're having fun.
You race to try to catch it, catch up,
To feel more, be more, not to miss out,
But the moments still pass right by.
Hard to tell the present from the past,
What was from what is momentarily.
It's not so much about you anymore,
What you are and what you could be,
But only about what you can give.
That becomes the only true measure
of time.

Be Maccabees

Musical Adaptation by the very talented Stephanie Romay, more information at facebook.com

I wish I could tell you
Everything is ok.
I wish I could say it
Everyday.

I wish I could tell you
Let's just go on our way
No looking, holding back
Anymore.

But I can't.

What I can tell you is
It WILL be ok
Everything's according to
His way.

But that doesn't mean that
There's not a lot to do
To pretend so is simply
Not true.

And I can't.

And yes, life is good,
Yes, G-d is good,
There's so much to thank
And enjoy

You know it's not easy
To be Maccabbees,
At peace while still
At war.

Yet, we can. Yes we can.

Todah

At what
You think
Is a
Low Point

In what
You think
Is a
Bad day

Take a
Deep breath
Say a
Thank you

And watch
How it
Beautifully unfolds.

Until Eliyahu Comes

There's so much doubt,
We feel knocked out,
Not quite sure
What it's all about,
Until Eliyahu comes.

We're in the dark,
Everything gray,
Forgot the taste,
Feel just decay,
Until Eliyahu comes.

And then he comes.
And then you know,
He'll always know
Just what to say
To change the mood.

It's about the good,
About the morning,
The wonderful
Ah!
It's about the day.

[In appreciation for R' Eli Stefansky.]

Szwalbe

Penso
Que sou
Algo
Não sou

Deixo o
Vento
Que me
Leve

E voo.

היום אם בקולו תשמעו

בעת נעילת שער
כי פנה היום
פתח אליהו ואמר
זה לא הדף
זה היום.

Fast

The heart
Overwhelmed
By pain

The mind
Enveloped
In fog

The mouth
Dry and
Speechless

The stomach
The least of
My concerns.

Begging for Change

B"H

I need change,
Give me
A five, and
I'll give you
A ten.

Heard from
A beggar
In Shul.
The beggar
Was me.

Return us
Hashem, and
We'll return.
Renew our days
As before.

Hashivenu
Hashem Eleichah
VeNashuva
Chadesh Yameinu
K'kedem.

Like beggars and paupers we knock on Your doors" (K'dalim u-ch'rashim dafaknu delatecha)